

Trade Career Starter Pack

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Your Complete Guide to Skipping College Debt

Why Choose Trades Over College?

- **No \$100K+ student debt** - Learn while you earn
- **High demand** - 80% of contractors report skilled labor shortages
- **Great pay** - Most trades pay \$50-80K+ mid-career
- **Job security** - People always need electricians, plumbers, HVAC
- **Early career** - Start earning at 20 instead of 22-24

Top 5 Trades for 2026

1. Electrician

- **Starting:** \$45-60K
- **Mid-career:** \$80-120K
- **Training:** 4-5 year apprenticeship
- **Outlook:** ■■■■■ (Excellent)

2. Plumber

- **Starting:** \$40-55K
- **Mid-career:** \$75-110K
- **Training:** 4-5 year apprenticeship
- **Outlook:** ■■■■■ (Excellent)

3. HVAC Technician

- **Starting:** \$40-50K
- **Mid-career:** \$70-100K
- **Training:** 6-24 months
- **Outlook:** ■■■■ (Very Good)

4. Welder

- **Starting:** \$35-45K
- **Mid-career:** \$65-95K
- **Training:** 6-18 months
- **Outlook:** ■■■■ (Very Good)

5. Dental Hygienist

- **Starting:** \$60-70K
- **Mid-career:** \$85-120K
- **Training:** 2 years (associate degree)
- **Outlook:** ■■■■■■ (Excellent)

How to Get Started (Step-by-Step)

1. **Take the Wrenchwork Assessment** - Find your best-fit trade
2. **Research local programs** - Community colleges, trade schools, unions
3. **Apply for apprenticeships** - Paid on-the-job training
4. **Get certified** - OSHA, trade-specific licenses
5. **Build experience** - Work under master tradespeople
6. **Become licensed** - Take state exam after apprenticeship

Questions to Ask Programs

- Is this program accredited?
- What's the job placement rate?
- How much does it cost?
- Is financial aid available?
- Can I work while in school?

Red Flags to Avoid

- ■ Schools that guarantee jobs
- ■ Programs costing \$30K+ for short certifications
- ■ No site visits or lab facilities
- ■ High-pressure sales tactics
- ■ No clear path to apprenticeship

Resources

- [BLS Occupational Outlook](<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/>)
- [Apprenticeship.gov](<https://www.apprenticeship.gov/>)
- [Trade-Schools.net](<https://www.trade-schools.net/>)